TEAM BRIEFING · OCTOBER 2026

Letters from History

History writes back.

Real, personalised letters from history's great minds, posted to children across the UK. When a child writes back, the next letter answers them.



A product of **Forem Innovations**
Status: built and tested end to end in test mode. Not yet launched.

THE IDEA

A pen pal from history who actually listens

Children aged 5 to 12 get beautifully printed letters through the letterbox from figures like Mary Anning, Isambard Kingdom Brunel and Ada Lovelace. Each letter is written for that child. When the child writes back, the pen pal answers their actual questions.

126,000
children home educated in England (autumn 2025, DfE), up from 111,700 a year earlier: our first audience

£7 / £12
a month for Story Letters (1 letter) or Pen Pal from History (2 letters, one answering the child)

~80%
estimated gross margin after printing, postage, AI and card fees

Why families will pay

- **Screen-free and real.** Paper, ink and a letter with their name on it.
- **It gets children writing.** Few things motivate a reluctant writer like a question from a pen pal.
- **History that sticks.** Every letter comes with a "Real history" card for parent and child to read together.
- **Perfect gift.** Grandparents are a natural second audience.

Why we're different

- Existing services (Heritage Letter, Letters From Afar, History By Mail; Banjo Robinson in the UK) send **the same letter to every child**. We found none that answers a child's own letter.
- AI makes truly personal, two-way letters affordable. People check them.
- Every pen pal writes on **stationery from their own era**, so each letter feels like a real object.

Why it can run with a small team

AI agents write, fact-check and lay out every letter. Stannp prints and posts them through Royal Mail, and Stripe takes payments. The team's daily job is **reviewing**: approving letters and handling any child's letter that needs a person. That takes minutes a day, not hours.

FOR FAMILIES

How it works

One

Sign up

Parent adds their child: first name, age, what they love, anything to avoid, and the address. They choose a plan and pay securely with Stripe.

Two

An introduction arrives

The first pen pal introduces themselves. Parents can choose to preview every letter before it's posted.

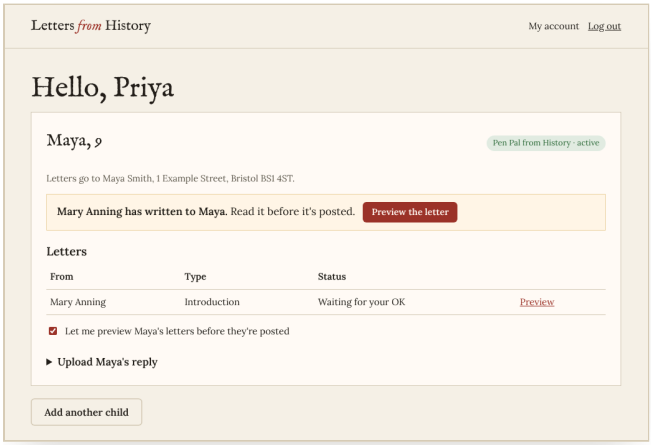
Three

The child writes back

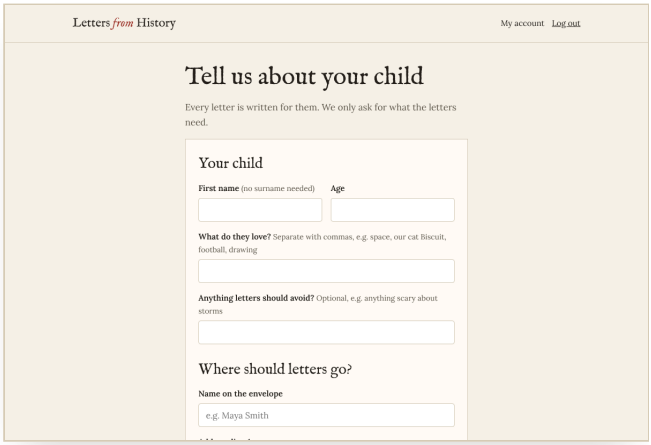
The parent snaps a photo of the reply. The next letter answers it. Every few months, a new pen pal takes over.



The home page. The hero shows the core promise: Leo's own letter, and Amelia Earhart's answer to every question in it.



The parent's account: letters, preview, reply upload, billing and their data.

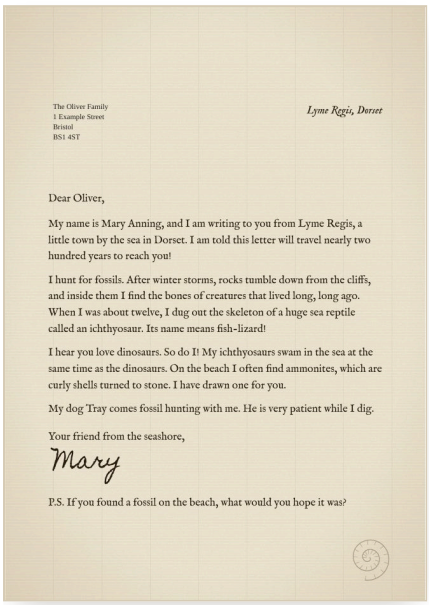


Adding a child: only what the letters need, nothing more.

THE PRODUCT

The letters

Each pen pal writes on paper from their own time, and every letter is written for one child. These are real sample letters, rendered exactly as they print on A4. The address shows through the envelope window.



The Oliver Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

Lyme Regis, Dorset

Dear Oliver,

My name is Mary Anning, and I am writing to you from Lyme Regis, a little town by the sea in Dorset. I am told this letter will travel nearly two hundred years to reach you!

I hunt for fossils. After winter storms, rocks tumble down from the cliffs, and inside them I find the bones of creatures that lived long, long ago. When I was about twelve, I dug out the skeleton of a huge sea reptile called an ichthyosaur. Its name means fish-lizard!

I hear you love dinosaurs. So do I! My ichthyosaurs swam in the sea at the same time as the dinosaurs. On the beach I often find ammonites, which are curly shells turned to stone. I have drawn one for you.

My dog Tray comes fossil hunting with me. He is very patient while I dig.

Your friend from the seashore,

Mary

P.S. If you found a fossil on the beach, what would you hope it was?

Mary Anning → Oliver, 7. Introduction. Victorian laid paper, ammonite sketch.



$E = mc^2$

The Maya Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

Princeton, New Jersey

Dear Maya,

A most curious thing happened this morning. I sat down at my desk here in Princeton to think about the universe, and instead my pen began writing to you, a girl who lives many years in my future! I do not understand how this letter will reach you. But I have learned that the best mysteries are the ones we cannot yet explain.

I am told you love space. So do I! When I was about five years old, my father showed me a compass. No matter how I turned it, the little needle pointed the same way, as if an invisible hand were pushing it. I could not stop wondering what that invisible thing was. I think that wondering is where all my science began.

Here is something I worked out about spaces: it is not stiff and empty like a box. Heavy things, like the Sun, bend space around them, a little like a bowling ball sitting on a trampoline. Even light, the fastest thing there is, curves as it passes by. In 1919, astronomers watched starlight bend around the Sun during an eclipse, just as I had predicted. I was very pleased, and also a little relieved!

I hear you draw comics and have a cat named Biscuit. When I was sixteen, I liked to imagine pictures in my head, such as racing alongside a beam of light. Perhaps you and I think in the same way.

Now I must practise my violin before supper. Mozart is very patient with my mistakes. My neighbours, perhaps less so.

Your friend across time,

Albert

P.S. If you drew a comic about Biscuit travelling through space, what would happen in it? I would very much like to know.

Einstein → Maya, 9. Typed page, pencil note, ink signature.



VIA AIR MAIL · PAR AVION

The Leo Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

Somewhere above the clouds

Dear Leo,

Thank you for your wonderful letter! A red Lego plane, just like my red plane? That made me smile all the way up to the clouds.

You asked if I was scared flying over the ocean all alone. Here is the truth: sometimes I was. The night was dark, a storm rumbled, and ice tried to stick to my wings. But I had practised and practised, and I knew my plane very well. Being brave does not mean you never feel scared. It means you keep going carefully, even when you do.

You also asked what I ate. On that long flight, I mostly sipped tomato juice through a straw! It kept me going for about fifteen hours, all the way to a farmer's field in Northern Ireland.

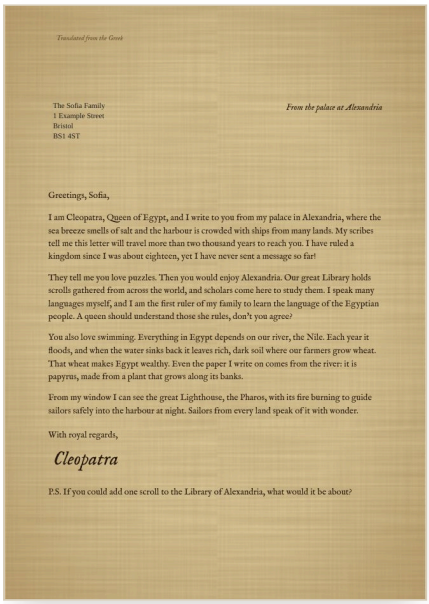
And you lost your first tooth! Congratulations, Leo. That is a big moment, a bit like a first flight.

Your friend in the sky,

Amelia

P.S. If you could fly your Lego plane anywhere in the whole world, where would you go?

Amelia Earhart → Leo, 7. Answers Leo's own questions. Airmail paper.



Translated from the Greek

The Sofia Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

From the palace at Alexandria

Greetings, Sofia,

I am Cleopatra, Queen of Egypt, and I write to you from my palace in Alexandria, where the sea breeze smells of salt and the harbour is crowded with ships from many lands. My scribes tell me this letter will travel more than two thousand years to reach you. I have ruled a kingdom since I was about eighteen, yet I have never sent a message so far!

They tell me you love puzzles. Then you would enjoy Alexandria. Our great Library holds scrolls gathered from across the world, and scholars come here to study them. I speak many languages myself, and I am the first ruler of my family to learn the language of the Egyptian people. A queen should understand those she rules, don't you agree?

You also love swimming. Everything in Egypt depends on our river, the Nile. Each year it floods, and when the water sinks back it leaves rich, dark soil where our farmers grow wheat. That wheat makes Egypt wealthy. Even the paper I write on comes from the river: it is papyrus, made from a plant that grows along its banks.

From my window I can see the great Lighthouse, the Pharos, with its fire burning to guide sailors safely into the harbour at night. Sailors from every land speak of it with wonder.

With royal regards,

Cleopatra

P.S. If you could add one scroll to the Library of Alexandria, what would it be about?

Cleopatra → Sofia, 10. Papyrus, "translated from the Greek".



The Sam Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

Milan

Dear Sam,

Forgive the ink spots on this page. I write quickly when an idea is chasing me, and this morning one chased me all the way across Milan. I am Leonardo, from the little town of Vinci, and I am told you are an inventor. Then we are already friends.

When I was young, I learned my trade in the workshop of Master Verrocchio in Florence. We painted, carved and built machines, all under one roof. I learned there that artists and engineers must both do the same thing first: look very, very carefully.

These days I am filling my notebooks with birds. I watch how they tilt their wings to turn, and how they ride the wind without flapping. I have drawn many designs for a machine that might let a person fly. None of them flies yet. But each drawing teaches me something the last one did not.

If you ever see my notebooks, you will notice something strange: I write backwards, from right to left. I am left-handed, and it suits me. To read it, you need a mirror. I have written one line for you at the bottom of this page so you can try.

They also tell me you play a game where you kick a ball. I would very much like to draw how your leg moves when you kick it. Everything that moves has a secret, Sam. The fun is finding it.

Your fellow inventor,

Leonardo

P.S. What is the best invention you have ever dreamed up? Draw it for me if you can.

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THE PRODUCT

Our pen pals

Eleven pen pals at launch, led by figures UK children meet in the history curriculum. Each has a verified fact sheet: the only facts a letter may use, plus "handle with care" rules.

#	Pen pal	Writes from	Children discover
1	**Mary Anning**	Lyme Regis, 1820s-30s	Fossils, ichthyosaurs, the Jurassic Coast
2	**Isambard Kingdom Brunel**	Westminster, 1840s-50s	Railways, bridges, iron steamships
3	**Ada Lovelace**	London, 1840s	Machines, maths, the first computer program
4	**Florence Nightingale**	London, 1857-65	Nursing, hygiene, statistics
5	**Charles Darwin**	Down House, Kent	HMS Beagle, Galápagos, observation
6	**Mary Seacole**	London, 1857-60	Jamaica, travel, healing, courage
7	**William Shakespeare**	Bankside, 1599-1608	The Globe, plays, words we still use
8-11	Einstein · Amelia Earhart · Leonardo da Vinci · Cleopatra	Their own eras	Space, flight, inventions, ancient Egypt

A friendship, not a series of leaflets

- **Introduction:** the first letter from every new pen pal.
- **Story:** a new chapter of their life, linked to the child's interests.
- **Reply:** answers every question in the child's letter.
- **Follow-up:** if no reply comes within 3 weeks.
- **Farewell:** after 3 letters, a goodbye. "Next month, a new pen pal from another time will write to you."

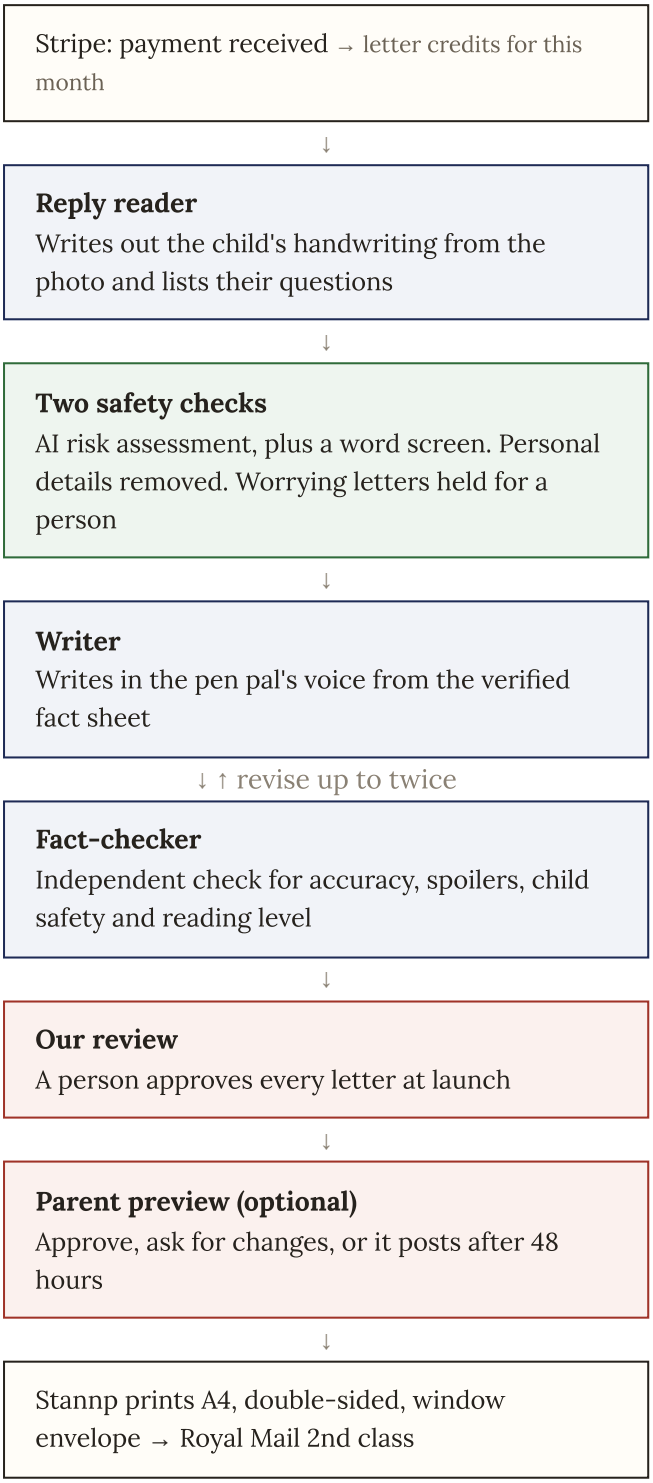
Accuracy rules every letter follows

- Only facts from the figure's fact sheet. No invented dates, events or quotations.
- Pen pals never know their own future, so there are no spoilers about their deaths.
- Anything imaginative (e.g. letters travelling through time) is marked on the Real history card.
- British English, at the child's reading level.

BEHIND THE SCENES

How a letter is made

AI agent · Safety check · A person · Service



Why this design

Each AI step has **one job**, and the fact-checker is separate from the writer, so mistakes get caught rather than repeated. Every letter's fact-check record is saved, which lets us back up the claim that "every fact is checked".

What the AI sees

The child's **first name, age, interests** and the words of their reply. It **never** sees surnames, addresses, emails or the parent's details.

Letter types and rotation

Which pen pal a child has, and whether the next letter is an introduction, story or farewell, is worked out from the letters already sent. Rejected letters never throw the rotation off.

Daily job

Once a day a scheduler triggers the run: read new replies, write the letters that payments allow, and queue them for review. Letters a parent hasn't responded to within 48 hours are posted.

SAFEGUARDING

Keeping children safe

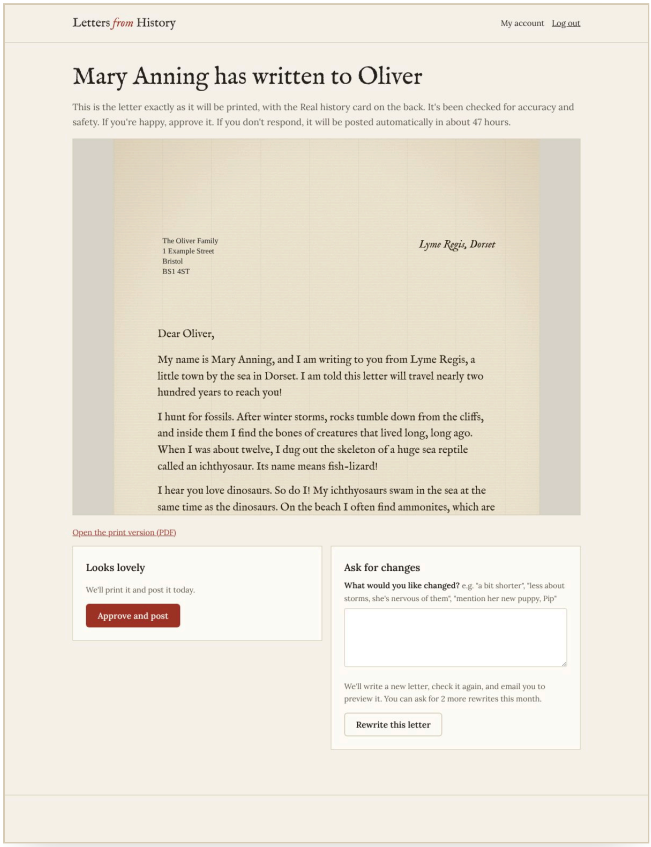
Children will sometimes tell a pen pal things they haven't told anyone. We designed for that from the start, and we treat it as the most important part of the product.

Layer	What it does
Parents only	Children have no accounts and no contact with anyone. Only a parent or guardian can sign up and upload replies.
AI safeguarding assessment	Every reply is graded none, low, high or urgent. It also flags inappropriate content, attempts to instruct the AI, and letters that don't look like a child wrote them.
Word screen (no AI)	Words about being hurt, self-harm, secrets, fear of an adult, running away, neglect or bullying **force a hold even if the AI says the letter is fine**. Tested against exactly that case.
Personal details removed	Addresses, phone numbers, emails, postcodes and social media handles are stripped out before anything is stored or written.
Hold, don't reply	A held reply gets no automatic answer. The safeguarding lead is emailed immediately, with URGENT in the subject when needed, and the photo is kept until a person has reviewed it.
Safe outgoing letters	Letters never ask for personal details, never repeat them, never promise meetings, calls or gifts, and never suggest secrets from parents. Low-level sadness (e.g. a pet died) gets a brief, kind acknowledgement and a nudge to talk to a trusted grown-up.
People	We approve every letter at launch. A named Designated Safeguarding Lead follows a written policy that sets out when to call 999, contact the council's children's services, or get advice from the NSPCC (0808 800 5000).

The automatic checks help a person notice. They never replace a person's judgement. False alarms are expected and fine. Full policy: docs/safeguarding.md.

PARENT PREVIEW

Parents see every letter first, if they want to



The preview shows the letter exactly as it will print.

How it works

1. We check and approve the letter first, so parents only see letters that have passed review.
2. The parent gets an email: "Mary Anning has written to Maya".
3. They **approve** it (posted today), **ask for changes** (e.g. "mention her new puppy, Pip"), or do nothing, and it posts after **48 hours**.

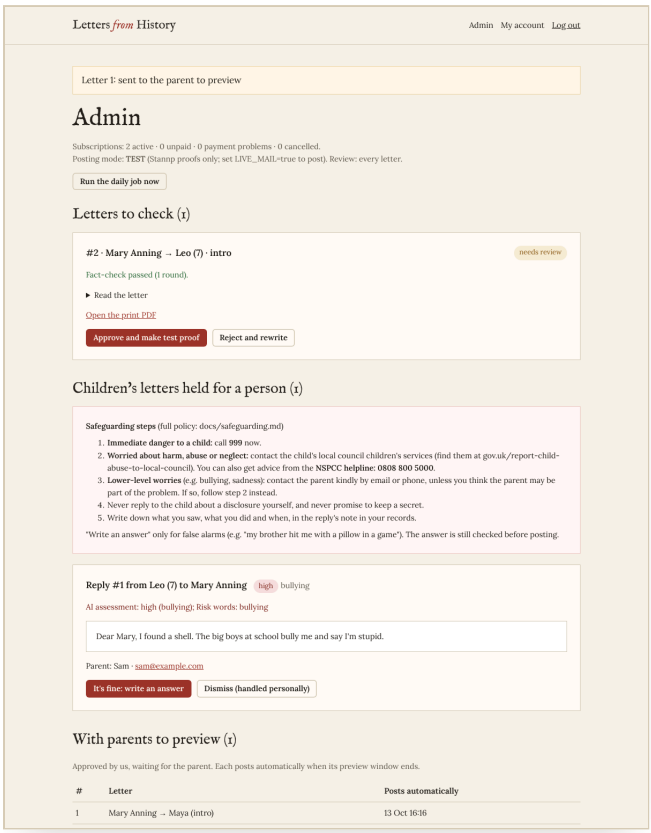
Limits that protect our costs

- At most **2 rewrites per child per month**.
- A rewrite reuses the same letter credit, so **it never creates extra letters**.
- Change requests: 500 characters maximum, personal details removed, and they can't override accuracy or safety.
- Every rewrite is checked by us again.
- Child replies: at most **4 uploads per child per month**.

Preview is a per-child setting, on by default at sign-up and changeable any time.

OPERATIONS

Running it day to day



The admin page: letters to check, children's letters held for a person (with the safeguarding steps right there), letters waiting on parents, and recent posting with costs.

Daily (5-10 minutes)

- Read and approve letters, or reject them for a fresh rewrite (the credit is returned).
- Handle any held child's letter the same day, following the safeguarding policy.

Monthly

- Stripe: check for failed payments.
- Stannp: check costs against our records.
- Read a few posted letters end to end.

Switches we control

LIVE_MAIL	Off = Stannp test proofs only. On = really printed and posted.
REVIEW_ALL	On = we approve every letter. Later, off = only flagged letters wait for us.

Roles we need

- **Safeguarding lead** and a deputy (basic training + DBS check)
- **Letter reviewer(s)**
- **Growth:** home-education groups, Mumsnet, grandparent gifting

BUSINESS

The numbers

All figures are estimates from current UK prices. They'll be replaced with real data from our first months.

Per subscriber per month	Story Letters (£7)	Pen Pal from History (£12)
Print, envelope and 2nd class postage (Stannp, ~£0.88 a letter)	£0.88	£1.76
AI: writing, fact-checking, reading replies	~£0.15	~£0.30
Card payments (Stripe UK)	~£0.31	~£0.38
Gross margin	**~£5.66 (81%)**	**~£9.56 (80%)**

300
subscribers ≈ **£3,000/month** revenue (at a £10 average)

1,000
subscribers ≈ **£10,000/month**: our year-one stretch goal

£90k
turnover before VAT registration applies (then 20% of the price goes to VAT)

Where customers come from

- **UK home-education communities:** Facebook groups, co-ops, Instagram home-ed accounts.
- **Mumsnet and Netmums:** Banjo Robinson, a UK pen-pal service, ran a Mumsnet product test with 88% parent satisfaction.
- **Grandparent gifting:** a prepaid "12 letters from history" plan for Christmas.
- **Word of mouth:** a child opening a letter that answers their own question is our best advert.

Risks we're managing

- **Accuracy:** verified fact sheets, an independent fact-checker, and human review.
- **Children's safety and data:** layered safeguarding, UK GDPR, data from parents only.
- **Novelty wearing off:** stories that continue, pen pals that rotate, and replies that get answered.
- **Cost abuse:** caps on rewrites and uploads, and every letter is paid for first.

WHERE WE ARE

Status and next steps

Built

done	Parent accounts, child profiles, reply uploads, data export and deletion
done	Stripe subscriptions (£7/£12), billing portal, payment webhooks
done	AI writer, fact-checker and reply reader; 11 pen pals; era stationery
done	Layered safeguarding and safeguarding policy
done	Admin review, parent preview, cost limits
done	Stannp UK print-and-post integration (test proofs by default)
done	Privacy policy and terms (Forem Innovations), launch guide
done	43 automated tests covering accounts, billing, letters, safety and preview

Tech: Python (FastAPI), Postgres (Supabase, London) or SQLite, Claude by Anthropic, Stripe, Stannp, Chromium for print PDFs, Docker.

Before launch

to do	Run end to end with live keys in test mode, and check Stannp proofs (address window)
to do	Hosting (UK/EU), Postgres, daily scheduler, email provider
to do	Company details, ICO registration, data processing terms with suppliers
to do	Solicitor review of privacy policy and terms
to do	Name a Safeguarding Lead and deputy; training and DBS checks
to do	Database migrations (Alembic) before real customer data

The plan

1. **Weeks 1-2:** test mode end to end; send 5-10 real letters to friends' children and film the reactions (with permission).
2. **Weeks 3-4:** legal, safeguarding and hosting; then a soft launch to founding families.
3. **Month 2+:** home-ed communities, Mumsnet and a Christmas gift campaign.